Family and children

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: The family in a changing world (197 words)

The shape of the family is changing in almost every country. The traditional **nuclear family** of two parents and their children now lives alongside the **single parent** household and the **extended family**, in which grandparents, aunts and cousins share responsibility. In many homes both parents work, so **childcare** has become a major expense, and the question of how to spend **quality time** with children is a daily worry.

Experts argue that a child's **upbringing** shapes personality for life. A parent who is too soft may **spoil** a child, while one who is too strict damages trust; many psychologists recommend an **authoritative** style that combines warmth with clear **discipline**. Parents must **nurture** talent and **supervise** activity, while also giving a growing teenager more **independence**. **Adolescence** is a delicate stage: a young person's **peer group** may matter more than any **role model** at home, and the **generation gap** can lead to arguments.

A **sibling** often becomes a child's first friend and rival, and daily **household** tasks teach **responsibility**. The strong **bond** between grandchildren and grandparents is a benefit that smaller families can lose. Whatever the structure, the most important factor is stability, and children generally **thrive on** attention, patience and love.

Useful phrases from the article

PHRASE	MEANING
thrive on	do especially well with

The 20 new words

WORD		MEANING	EXAMPLE
upbringing	n	the way a child is raised	*A caring upbringing builds confidence.*
nuclear family	n	parents and their children	*The nuclear family is common in cities.*
extended family	n	relatives such as grandparents and cousins	*Extended families often live together.*
generation gap	n	difference in views between old and young	*The generation gap can cause arguments.*
single parent	n	a mother or father raising children alone	*Single parents need more support.*
childcare	n	looking after children while parents work	*Childcare costs are very high.*
role model	n	a person others want to copy	*Parents are the first role models.*

peer group	n	friends of the same age	*A child's peer group affects behavior.*
sibling	n	a brother or sister	*His sibling is two years younger.*
adolescence	n	the teenage years	*Adolescence is a difficult period.*
spoil	v	to give a child too much	*Parents should not spoil their children.*
authoritative	adj	having authority but fair	*An authoritative style works better than a strict one.*
nurture	v	to care for and help grow	*Parents must nurture their children's talents.*
household	n	people living in one home	*The average household has three people.*
discipline	n	training in correct behavior	*Children need clear discipline.*
bond	n	a close connection	*The bond between grandparents and grandchildren is strong.*
supervise	v	to watch over someone	*Young children must be supervised.*
independence	n	the ability to live without help	*Teenagers want more independence.*
responsibility	n	a duty you must perform	*Chores teach children responsibility.*
quality time	n	time fully given to someone	*Busy parents try to spend quality time with children.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

WORD		MEANING
urbanization	n	the growth of cities
congestion	n	too much traffic
public transport	n	buses, trains and trams for everyone
commuter	n	a person who travels to work each day
rush hour	n	the busiest time of the day for traffic
affordable	adj	not too expensive
overcrowded	adj	too full of people
suburb	n	a residential area outside the city center
skyscraper	n	a very tall building
pedestrian	n	a person walking

Practice: fill the gaps

household · discipline · responsibility · authoritative · single parent · sibling · quality time · bond

1. The average _____ has three people.
2. Children need clear _____.
3. Chores teach children _____.
4. An _____ style works better than a strict one.
5. _____ need more support.
6. His _____ is two years younger.
7. Busy parents try to spend _____ with children.
8. The _____ between grandparents and grandchildren is strong.

More words on this topic (not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)

adopt (v): to legally take a child as your own
baby boomer (n): a person born after the Second World War
bring up (v): to raise a child
childhood (n): the time of being a child
custody (n): legal care of a child
divorce (n): the legal end of a marriage
domestic (adj): connected with the home
elderly (adj): old
foster (v): to care for a child not your own
guardian (n): a person responsible for a child
heir (n): a person who will inherit
homework (n): school work done at home
infant (n): a very young child
inherit (v): to receive from a relative
lone parent (n): a single mother or father
maternity leave (n): time off work for a new mother
paternity leave (n): time off work for a new father
nanny (n): a person paid to look after children
newborn (n): a very young baby
orphan (n): a child without parents
overprotective (adj): too careful about a child
parenting (n): the act of raising children
relatives (n): members of the family
sibling rivalry (n): competition between brothers and sisters
strict (adj): requiring obedience
teenager (n): a person aged 13 to 19
toddler (n): a child learning to walk
unconditional love (n): love with no limits
well-behaved (adj): having good manners

Topic kit: what to know about this topic

Writing Task 2 questions you may meet

1. Some people think parents should be strict; others believe in a relaxed style. Discuss both views and give your opinion.
2. Children spend less time with their families today. What are the causes and effects?
3. Many elderly people live alone. What problems does this cause and how can they be solved?
4. Both parents should work, even when children are small. To what extent do you agree or disagree?

Ideas you can use in essays and in speaking

- **For / good:** Clear rules and discipline give children security and teach responsibility.
- **Against / bad:** Too much strictness can damage trust and creativity.
- **For / good:** Two incomes help families with the cost of living.
- **Against / bad:** Young children need parents' time, and childcare is expensive.
- **For / good:** Extended families provide support for children and old people.
- **Against / bad:** Modern jobs and housing force families to live far apart.

Speaking

Part 1

- Do you have a big family?
- Who are you closest to?
- Do you spend time with your relatives?
- What do you do with your family at weekends?
- Do you want children?

Part 3

- How has family life changed?
- Who should look after elderly parents?
- What makes a good parent?
- Do children need strict rules?

Part 2 cue card. Describe a member of your family you admire. You should say: who they are, what they do, what they are like, and explain why you admire them.

Answers

1. household (household)
2. discipline (discipline)
3. responsibility (responsibility)
4. authoritative (authoritative)
5. Single parents (single parent)
6. sibling (sibling)
7. quality time (quality time)
8. bond (bond)